

moved there from Siberia, as had his mother, an amateur musician. Dmitri began piano lessons with his mother at the age of nine—he soon showed remarkable talent, and a particular interest in composing.

At the age of 13, he was admitted to the Petrograd Conservatory, whose alumni included Tchaikovsky and Prokofiev. Since the revolutions of 1917, however, the Conservatory had become less tolerant of innovation, and the curriculum was prescribed by Soviet ideology. As a young composer, Shostakovich had little interest in emulating the great Russian composers, preferring the exciting new music of Stravinsky and Prokofiev, a tendency that was frowned on by his teachers.



PETROGRAD, 1920

The Communist International Congress in Shostakovich's home town (formerly St. Petersburg). The city was named Leningrad after the death of Lenin (shown left) in 1924.